

Article (Author, Year)	Main Objective	Methodology	Key Findings	Main Conclusion	Citation
Kraut et al. (1998)	To examine the social and psychological impact of early internet use on new users over 1-2 years.	Longitudinal field study with questionnaires and automatic usage logging (N=169).	Greater internet use was linked to declines in family communication, smaller social circles, and increased depression and loneliness.	The internet, though a social technology, can paradoxically lead to social disengagement and reduced psychological well-being.	Kraut, R., Patterson, M., Lundmark, V., Kiesler, S., Mukopadhyay, T., & Scherlis, W. (1998). Internet paradox: A social technology that reduces social involvement and psychological well-being? <i>American Psychologist</i> , 53(9), 1017–1031.
Ellison et al. (2007)	To investigate the link between Facebook use and the creation and maintenance of social capital in college students.	Survey of undergraduate students (N=286).	Facebook use was strongly associated with all three types of social capital (bonding, bridging, and maintained). Users with low self-esteem appeared to gain more benefits.	Social network sites can be valuable tools for accumulating social resources and may be particularly beneficial for those with lower psychological well-being.	Ellison, N. B., Steinfield, C., & Lampe, C. (2007). The benefits of Facebook "Friends:" social capital and college students' use of online social network sites. <i>Journal of Computer-Mediated Communication</i> , 12(4), 1143–1168. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1083-6101.2007.00367.x
Bollen et al. (2011)	To determine if collective mood on Twitter could predict the stock market.	Analysis of 9.8 million tweets using sentiment tracking tools and correlating the results with the Dow Jones Industrial Average (DJIA).	A public mood dimension of "Calm" predicted the daily up-and-down changes of the DJIA with 86.7% accuracy.	The collective sentiment expressed on social media is a powerful societal indicator that can even predict major economic events.	Bollen, J., Mao, H., & Zeng, X. (2011). Twitter mood predicts the stock market. <i>Journal of Computational Science</i> , 2(1), 1–8. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jocs.2010.12.007
Chou & Edge (2012)	To examine how using Facebook affects people's perceptions of others' lives.	Survey of undergraduate students (N=425).	Longer and more frequent Facebook use was associated with the belief that others are happier and have better lives, due to cognitive biases.	Facebook use can create distorted social perceptions by showcasing curated, positive content, leading users to believe others are better off.	Chou, H.-T. G., & Edge, N. (2012). "They are happier and having better lives than I am": The impact of using Facebook on perceptions of others' lives. <i>Cyberpsychology, Behavior, and Social Networking</i> , 15(2), 117–121. https://doi.org/10.1089/cyber.2011.0324
Steers et al. (2014)	To see how social comparison on Facebook is linked to depressive symptoms.	Two studies: a cross-sectional survey (N=180) and a 14-day diary study (N=152).	The relationship between time spent on Facebook and depression is mediated by social	Social comparison is the key psychological mechanism explaining how Facebook use can lead to depressive symptoms.	Steers, M.-L. N., Wickham, R. E., & Acitelli, L. K. (2014). Seeing everyone else's highlight reels: How Facebook usage is linked to depressive symptoms. <i>Journal of Social and</i>

			comparison. People feel depressed when comparing themselves to others' "highlight reels."		Clinical Psychology, 33(8), 701–731. https://doi.org/10.1521/jscp.2014.33.8.701
McLean et al. (2015)	To analyze the link between selfie-related activities and body dissatisfaction in adolescent girls.	Cross-sectional survey of grade-seven girls (N=101).	The active investment in and manipulation of self-photos was most strongly associated with body-related concerns, more so than just sharing them.	Active engagement in curated self-presentation (e.g., photo editing) is a significant correlate of body image issues in young girls.	McLean, S. A., Paxton, S. J., Wertheim, E. H., & Masters, J. (2015). Photoshopping the selfie: Self photo editing and photo investment are associated with body dissatisfaction in adolescent girls. International Journal of Eating Disorders, 48(8), 1132–1140. https://doi.org/10.1002/eat.22449
Mazlum & Atalay (2022)	To develop and validate a scale to measure the Fear of Missing Out (FoMO) in university students.	Scale development study using factor analysis with two student samples (N=343, N=283).	A valid and reliable 17-item scale was created that measures two dimensions of FoMO: private and social.	FoMO is a measurable psychological construct with distinct private and social facets that can be reliably assessed.	Mazlum, M. M., & Atalay, A. (2022). Developing the fear of missing out (FoMO) scale for university students: The validity and reliability study. Journal of Pedagogical Research, 6(4), 20–34. https://doi.org/10.33902/JPR.202215485
Gentzler et al. (2023)	To find out which platforms and individual differences moderate the link between social media use and teen depression.	Longitudinal survey of adolescents (N=237).	The link to depression was significant for Instagram, TikTok, and YouTube, but not others. Being less extraverted increased the negative effects.	The impact of social media is not uniform; it depends on the specific platform and the user's personality, putting certain adolescents at greater risk.	Gentzler, A. L., Hughes, J. L., Johnston, M., & Alderson, J. E. (2023). Which social media platforms matter and for whom? Examining moderators of links between adolescents' social media use and depressive symptoms. Journal of Adolescence, 95(8), 1725–1748. https://doi.org/10.1002/jad.12243
Rippé et al. (2023)	To use attachment theory to explain how insecurity, loneliness, and FoMO drive consumer	Survey of emerging adults (N=509) using structural equation modeling.	Insecure attachment and loneliness were identified as antecedents of FoMO, which in turn drives behaviors like retail patronage	Deeper psychological needs, like the need for secure attachment, fuel anxieties like FoMO, which can motivate compensatory real-world behaviors.	Rippé, C. B., Smith, B., & Gala, P. (2023). A psychological examination of attachment insecurity, loneliness, and fear of missing out as drivers of retail patronage among emerging adults.

	behavior.		to resolve "relational deficits."		International Journal of Consumer Studies, 47(5), 1838–1852. https://doi.org/10.1111/ijcs.12958
Flores Bravo & Ramenzoni (2025)	To study the impact of AI-generated and user-edited images on body image perception.	Experimental tasks and open-ended questions with young adults (N=24).	Participants could detect obvious AI edits but struggled with subtle ones. They expressed a preference for authentic, unaltered images.	While new technology challenges our perception of reality, there is an underlying preference for authenticity, creating a cultural tension.	Flores Bravo, I. M., & Ramenzoni, V. C. (2025). Perceptions of A.I.-enhanced bodies: Autonomy, authenticity, and preferences among young adults. Proceedings of the Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society, 47. https://escholarship.org/uc/item/76b1k3rs

Summary

It's strange to think about now, but the **first big look** into **how the internet affects people** found a major paradox. Back in 1998, a longitudinal study by Kraut and his team discovered that even though the internet was a social tool, the **more people used it, the more their real-world social lives suffered**. They talked less with family, their circle of friends got smaller, and they reported feeling more depressed and lonely. The running theory was that **the easy, shallow connections people made online** were **pushing out the more meaningful, real-life relationships**.

When platforms like Facebook arrived, the picture got a bit more complicated. At first, it seemed like a net positive. A 2007 study by Ellison, Steinfield, and Lampe showed that Facebook was great for building what they call “**social capital**”, basically, the benefits we get from our relationships. It helped students **stay in touch with old friends** and even seemed to **give a boost to users with low self-esteem**. But a **darker side** started to emerge as researchers began to **pinpoint** why **these platforms** could **make us feel bad**. A key insight came in 2012 from Chou and Edge, who found that the **more time** people **spent on Facebook**, the **more they believed everyone else was happier and living better lives**. This happens because we see a constant stream of good news and assume it's the whole story. A couple of years later, research by Steers, Wickham, and Acitelli connected the dots, confirming that this **constant social comparison** to everyone's online "highlight reels" is what directly leads to higher **depressive symptoms**.

This **pressure to perform** is cranked up to eleven on visual platforms like Instagram, creating a minefield for body image and our sense of what's real. A 2015 study on teen girls by McLean et al. found that it wasn't just sharing selfies that was the problem; it was the **heavy emotional investment and digital editing** of those photos that was **tightly linked to feeling bad about their bodies**. Nowadays, AI has made this even more complex. A 2025 study by Flores Bravo and Ramezonii found that while it's easy to catch obvious AI fakes, small tweaks can still fool us, blurring our sense of what's genuine. Interestingly, **people in the study often preferred raw, unedited images, exactly as they were captured**. The takeaway? These platforms aren't only about comparing ourselves to unrealistic ideals, they can also be **spaces for**

exploring identity. For instance, research from Julianito and Seran in 2025 shows that Instagram can act as a space where people, especially those with non-binary identities, express themselves and challenge old norms.

So, what's driving all this online activity? Often, it boils down to some very deep-seated human needs. A 2022 study by Mazlum and Atalay zeroed in on the **Fear of Missing Out (FoMO)**—that nagging anxiety that everyone is having amazing experiences without you. But that fear doesn't come from nowhere. A 2023 study by Rippé, Smith, and Gala connected FoMO to even more fundamental feelings, like loneliness and insecure **attachment styles** from our past. They showed that when people feel these "relational deficits," they can be motivated to do other things, like shop, to try and fill that void.

Ultimately, it's a mistake to talk about "social media" as if it's all one thing. The impact is **far from uniform**. A 2023 study by Gentzler et al. showed that the platform really matters: for teens, the link to depression was strong for Instagram, TikTok, and YouTube, but not so much for Snapchat, Facebook, or Twitter. Your **personality** plays a **big role**, too. For instance, being **less extraverted** made teens **more vulnerable** to the **negative effects**. When you zoom out from the individual, the combined effect of all these online feelings is staggering. A 2011 study by Bollen, Mao, and Zeng showed that the collective "mood" on Twitter was so powerful that they could use it to predict the daily swings of the Dow Jones stock market with **86.7% accuracy**.

Looking at all the evidence, a clear picture emerges. Social media is a bit of a paradox. It gives us a real way to connect with others, but **its design almost forces us into a game of social comparison**, which can be a slippery slope toward feeling depressed and anxious about our own situation.

Of course, it doesn't hit everyone the same way. The platform you use, your own personality, and even underlying worries like the fear of missing out (FoMO) can completely change the experience for an individual. But what's truly mind-blowing is what happens when you multiply those individual feelings by millions. That collective online mood is so powerful, it has actually been used to forecast the stock market. It's the ultimate proof that the line separating our digital lives from our real-world well-being has basically vanished.